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ORIGINAL PAPER

Nonprofit Brand Strength: What Is It? How Is It Measured? What Are Its Outcomes?

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Abstract Nonprofit brand strength is conceptualized as the degree to which a nonprofit brand is well known to a target group, is perceived favorably by a target group, and is perceived to be remarkable by a target group. Hence, the authors conceptualize nonprofit brand strength as a priori having three dimensions: familiarity, remarkability, and attitude. The authors report the development of a nonprofit brand strength scale, using a series of charity brands, in three separate studies, supporting the scale's reliability and validity. The scale's ability to differentiate charities based on their respective nonprofit brand strength levels is demonstrated. Moreover, nonprofit brand strength is shown to be antecedent to a target group's affective dispositions and behavioral intentions toward the nonprofit brand.

Résumé La force de la marque d'une organisation à but non lucratif est considérée comme le degré de reconnaissance de cette marque par un groupe cible, le degré de perception favorable et le degré de perception comme étant remarquable par ce

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groupe. En conséquence, les auteurs conceptualisent la force de la marque d'une organisation à but non lucratif comme comprenant a priori trois aspects: familiarité, caractère distinctif et attitude. Les auteurs décrivent la conception d'une échelle de force des marques des organisations à but non lucratif grâce à un ensemble de marques d'associations caritatives, dans trois études distinctes, pour confirmer la fiabilité et la validité de l'échelle. La capacité de l'échelle à différencier les organisations caritatives en fonction des niveaux de force des marques de leurs organisations à but non lucratif respectives est démontrée. De plus, il est montré que la force de la marque d'une organisation à but non lucratif précède les dispositions affectives et les intentions comportementales du groupe cible envers la marque.

Zusammenfassung Die Markenstärke im gemeinnützigen Bereich wird begrifflich erfasst als das Maß, in dem eine gemeinnützige Marke bei einer Zielgruppe bekannt ist, positiv von einer Zielgruppe wahrgenommen wird und von einer Zielgruppe als bemerkenswert erachtet wird. Daher konzeptualisieren die Autoren die Markenstärke im gemeinnützigen Sektor grundsätzlich als einen Bereich mit drei Dimensionen: Vertrautheit, Besonderheit und Einstellung. Die Autoren berichten über die Entwicklung einer Skala zur Markenstärke im gemeinnützigen Bereich unter Hinzuziehung einer Reihe von gemeinnützigen Marken in drei separaten Studien als Beweis für die Zuverlässigkeit und Gültigkeit der Skala. Es wird demonstriert, dass die Skala zwischen Wohltätigkeitsorganisationen beruhend auf ihren jeweiligen Markenstärken unterscheiden kann. Darüber hinaus wird dargelegt, dass die Markenstärke im gemeinnützigen Bereich den affektiven Dispositionen und Verhaltensabsichten einer Zielgruppe gegenüber der gemeinnützigen Marke vorhergeht.

Resumen La fortaleza de la marca sin ánimo de lucro se conceptualiza como el grado en el que una marca sin ánimo de lucro es conocida para un grupo objetivo, es percibida favorablemente por un grupo objetivo, y es percibida como destacable por un grupo objetivo. De ahí que los autores conceptualicen la fortaleza de la marca sin ánimo de lucro considerando que tiene a priori tres dimensiones: familiaridad, destacabilidad y actitud. Los autores informan del desarrollo de una escala de fortaleza de la marca sin ánimo de lucro, utilizando una serie de marcas de organizaciones benéficas, en tres estudios separados, que apoyan la fiabilidad y validez de la escala. Se demuestra la capacidad de la escala para diferenciar a las organizaciones benéficas basándose en sus respectivos niveles de fortaleza de la marca sin ánimo de lucro. Asimismo, se muestra que la fortaleza de la marca sin ánimo de lucro antecede a las disposiciones afectivas de un grupo objetivo y a las intenciones comportamentales hacia la marca sin ánimo de lucro.

Keywords Brand strength · Scale development · Nonprofit brand management · Nonprofit marketing

Introduction

What does it mean to say that a nonprofit brand is strong? What is nonprofit brand strength? There has been substantial prior research within the nomological network concerning nonprofit brands. However, the absence of conceptualizing and measuring nonprofit brand strength is a substantive gap. While prior nonprofit research has discussed strong brands in terms of their likely correlates or outcomes, the field has not conceptualized the nature and dimensionality of the construct.

In this article, we present a conceptualization of nonprofit brand strength and the development of its scale. We will use the terms nonprofit brand strength and brand strength interchangeably to refer to the same construct. We review the relevant literature in both the commercial and nonprofit contexts to inform our conceptualization. The construct definition is then followed by a three-study scale development project. Additionally, outcome variables are included in our analysis to provide insights into the potential relationships between nonprofit brand strength and outcome variables it influences.

Because nonprofit brand strength has positive outcomes, it was surprising to discover that the conceptualization and measurement of (also “for-profit”) brand strength received little attention, even in articles in which terms like “brand strength” or “strong brands” were used and the importance of strong brands mentioned (Henderson et al. 2003; Hoeffler and Keller 2003; John et al. 2006; Keller 1993). François and MacLachlan (1995) “operationally define” brand strength by measuring anticipated brand strength outcome measures. However, defining a construct in terms of its consequents or outcomes is a flawed approach. Summers (2001) writes, “One cannot define a construct in terms of its antecedents or its consequences. Moreover, trying to do so means that the proposed theoretical linkage between A and B would not be empirically testable (i.e., it could not be falsified); rather, it would be true by definition” (p. 407).

Early brand research focused on the competitiveness of consumer product brands for managerial effectiveness (Dacin and Smith 1994); hence, the emphasis was not on understanding the nature of the brand strength construct. The interest in brand strength appears to be centered on its expected outcomes. Consequently, researchers used a variety of proxies to “operationalize” brand strength in order to examine other concepts of greater interest. Biel (1992) argues that marketing scholars have not articulated the underlying characteristics that make a brand strong. Two decades later, the brand strength construct still has not been adequately conceptualized, neither in a for-profit nor in a nonprofit context. MacKenzie (2003) finds that failure to adequately specify the conceptual meaning of a study’s focal constructs is a common source of invalid research.

Conceptualizing Brand Strength

According to De Chernatony and Riley (1998, p. 417), there have been a “plethora” of brand definitions. Ironically, Bastos and Levy (2012) criticize these definitions as undeveloped. Therefore, we will be clear in our use of the term, a necessary prerequisite for defining the nonprofit brand strength construct.

We define a brand image as a target group's comprehension of the branded object based on their experiences relating to the branded object and information they have received pertaining to the branded object. Brand image refers to a cluster of attributes and associations that consumers connect to the brand name (Biel 1992). Brand image is the concept of a brand that is held by the consumer (Dobni and Zinkhan 1990); its intangible, derived meaning (Wood 2000).

Prior marketing research proposed that changes in brand image could lead to changes in brand equity (Biel 1992). That is, if the attribute mix of a product could be improved, then one would expect the monetary value of the brand to improve. Biel (1992) posits that the mechanism through which brand image influences brand equity is by making the brand stronger. Additionally, Biel notes that one can agree upon which brands are strong versus weak, but there is no conceptualization of the brand strength construct in prior literature.

We believe that a certain combination of brand attributes (brand image) is a necessary but insufficient condition for increasing brand strength. The target audience must also be sufficiently knowledgeable about the brand object to understand what brand attributes it contains. Furthermore, from the perspective of the target audience, the bundle of brand attributes must compare favorably to the brand's competitors.

In conceptualizing nonprofit brand strength, we believe that an understanding of the construct requires identifying its nature and facets. Brand strength has a comparative quality. If a nonprofit brand is weak or strong, it is perceived to be so by a comparison with its peer brands. If a brand object has no direct competitors, target audience members will still evaluate it by comparing it with the nearest brands to its type from their experiential knowledge base. In the extreme case in which a brand object is a unique pioneer, the harbinger of its own product class, the audience members will evaluate the brand object not in comparison with its in-class or near-class peers, but in comparison with members' beliefs about how the pioneer brand object ought to perform (having some basic performance expectations or standards in mind).

The nature of the brand object (necessity or not) and its competitive environment influence audience perceptions and, thus, brand strength. For example, car owners need fuel (gasoline or petrol). They need the fuel and must buy it. However, car owners may believe that fuel is an undifferentiated commodity and make their selection purely on costs. If one brand of fuel is consistently lower-priced than other brands, the consumers may develop a brand preference for that fuel brand, making the brand the strongest in its class. As another example, individuals may only have one electric utility from which to get their home electricity. Having no alternatives for a necessity, consumers have no choice but to buy from that monopoly. This circumstance does not make the utility a strong brand since consumers' lack of brand preference could be demonstrated if alternatives were available.

In the context of charities, which are not necessities (like car fuel or electricity), if no charities in a given class are strong brands, then individuals may choose not to donate. In the case in which a charity is a strong brand, in comparison with its peers, donors may develop a brand preference for the strong brand and choose to channel their support to that charity.

The determining feature is audience member choice. The more choice audience members have, the more important brand strength is for organizational success. In the electric utility case, consumers have no choice. Hence, from the perspective of the monopoly utility, brand strength is managerially irrelevant. In the case of a charity for which potential donors can choose whether or not to donate and, if they choose to donate, they have several alternatives to target their support, brand strength is quite important.

The strength of a brand is based on the perceptions of a target group or audience of managerial interest to the organization. This view is consistent with that of Dacin and Smith (1994), who argue that brand strength should be construed from the perspective of a target audience or group. For a consumer product brand, this might be the target consumer group. For a nonprofit organization, this might be the general population or some population subgroup. Based on our review of the branding literature, we believe that a strong nonprofit brand, compared to a weak nonprofit brand, has the following properties.

A Strong Nonprofit Brand is Well Known

A nonprofit organization would want its brand to be well known to target groups of managerial importance. The characteristic of being well known refers to how familiar a target group is with a branded object. Napoli (2006) argues that the more well known a charity brand is, the stronger it is.

Prior research in consumer products branding has recognized the importance of brand familiarity and its probable antecedent relationship to purchase intention, repeat purchase, brand recall, and other consequent variables. Hoeffler and Keller (2003) argue that consumer familiarity (based on ownership, prior knowledge, or brand exposure) has served, in prior research, as a proxy for strong brands.

There is some similarity between brand familiarity and brand awareness. Brand awareness, however, is a construct with limited applicability and which is subsumed into brand familiarity. One is either aware of the brand object or not. It is not descriptive to assess the degree to which one is aware of a brand. For example, what does it mean to say one is very aware of the brand object or merely somewhat aware of the brand object? However, brand familiarity incorporates brand awareness and adds a magnitude facet. For example, if one is not aware of the brand then one is also not familiar with the brand. If one is aware of the brand, the degree to which one is familiar with the brand will vary along a familiarity continuum.

Brand familiarity is a necessary but insufficient component of brand strength. While a strong brand may be one with which an important group is familiar, a familiar brand may be unpopular or disliked (and therefore, weak). It is possible for a familiar brand to be perceived as mediocre in comparison to a peer brand, suggesting the mediocre brand is comparatively weak. Hence, in addition to being a familiar brand, the brand must also be perceived favorably by the target group of interest. This leads into the second characteristic of a strong nonprofit brand.

A Strong Nonprofit Brand is Favorably Perceived

Being perceived positively relates to the attitude concept. Since attitude has a valence and a magnitude, attitude is well suited as a means of assessing the degree of favorability with which the organization or other branded object is perceived by its target group. Prior research in commercial branding has recognized the importance of brand attitude and its probable antecedent relationship to outcome variables indicative of a strong brand, such as brand equity (Faircloth et al. 2001). Dacin and Smith (1994) argue that the favorability of consumers' brand predispositions is important in conceptualizing brand strength.

Like familiarity, a favorable attitude is a necessary but insufficient component of a strong brand. For example, most well-known charities are perceived favorably by the public and enjoy a favorable attitude. For a charity to be considered the strongest brand in its class, however, something additional is required. Among charities having similar missions and attracting donations and volunteers from the same population, it is the stand-out, exemplar, and best organization which will attract the most support, thus indicating an additional characteristic is also a component of nonprofit brand strength.

A Strong Nonprofit Brand is Exceptional and Extraordinary in Comparison to Peer Brands

This brand strength characteristic pertains to how exceptional a target group perceives a brand in comparison with other brands in its class. Brand strength is an interesting concept in that it has a comparative quality. If a community has three similar nonprofit organizations, the organization with the greatest brand strength would be perceived as exceptional in comparison with the other two organizations. If an organization is viewed as no better than similar organizations, then this perception of being average would imply a brand of average strength. If an organization is perceived as being worse than similar organizations, then one would expect this organization's brand strength to be below average. Prior literature strongly supports the argument that a strong brand needs to be perceived as exceptional and extraordinary. Biel (1992), for example, argues that salience within a product class is a requirement of being a dominant brand. Simoes and Dibb (2001) argue that a dominant brand needs to have some aspect of uniqueness and it needs to be perceived as representing quality. We believe they were referring to the need of a dominant brand (the strongest brand in its class) to be perceived as differentiated and superior in comparison with its peer brands.

Brand remarkability, as a dimension of brand strength, helps to overcome a conceptual error in prior literature that conflated differentiation with superiority. For example, Aaker (1996) argues that differentiation (being different from competing brands) was the essential characteristic of a brand that enabled it to command a price premium. We argue, however, that simply being different is insufficient to make a brand strong. A brand object can be different, but in a negative manner. A brand object can be different, but in a manner that does not make it the preferred choice among peer brands. Hence, remarkability is assessed from the perspective of the target audience or group and refers to the extent to which the brand object stands out in an exceptional manner from peer brands.

Construct Definitions

Based on the preceding discussion and literature review, we define nonprofit brand strength as the degree to which a nonprofit brand is well known to a target group, is perceived favorably by a target group, and is perceived to be remarkable in comparison to peer brands by a target group. Hence, we conceptualize nonprofit brand strength as having three dimensions: familiarity, attitude, and remarkability. Nonprofit brand familiarity refers to the level of knowledge the target audience has about the brand object. Nonprofit brand attitude refers to the degree to which a brand object is perceived favorably by a target group. Nonprofit brand remarkability refers to the degree to which a brand object is perceived by a target group to be extraordinary.

Developing the Nonprofit Brand Strength Scale

Our general procedure is presented in Fig. 1. We began by generating and purifying an initial item pool (step 1). Then, we undertook several procedures for refining the scale (step 2) before we validated our newly developed scale (step 3).

Developing Initial Item Pool

To generate an initial broad set of statements, we solicited responses from 55 marketing students at a German and at a Canadian university. After defining brand

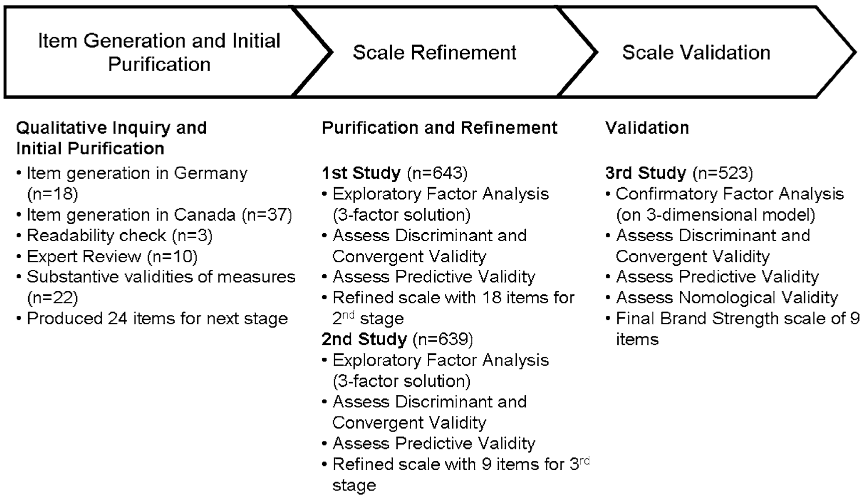

Fig. 1 Scale development process

strength, the students were asked to create statements that reflected its meaning. In total, 377 statements were generated. We then checked the items for quality in terms of grammar, spelling, and clarity. We deleted some items that were clearly unsuitable (lacked face validity) or were repeated previously. This resulted in a set of 58 candidate items.

Expert Review of Candidate Items

Nine doctoral students and a professor were presented with the candidate items. These individuals were asked to evaluate the item list in terms of face validity, content validity, writing quality, and redundancy. This process resulted in a refined set of 29 items.

Substantive Validities of Items

The next step involved assessing the substantive validity of measures in a pretest CFA procedure developed by Anderson and Gerbing (1991). A sample of 22 individuals participated in an item sorting task. We calculated the proportion of substantive agreements and the substantive-validity coefficients for all items. This procedure resulted in the deletion of 5 items, resulting in a refined item pool of 24 items (Reviewer Appendix A) to use in the first developmental study.

Nature of Measurement Model

MacKenzie et al. (2005) recommend considering the relationship between a construct and its measures. Based on criteria from prior literature (Coltman et al. 2008; Jarvis et al. 2003), we propose that this relationship is reflective.

First Developmental Study

We developed an online questionnaire. The scale items were statements to which participants indicated their level of agreement in a seven-point Likert format. Brand strength was measured for two organizations: World Vision (WV) and Operation Smile (OS). They were selected because prior research found both to be relatively well known, but WV to be more familiar to our population than OS (Cavill 2011). Selecting two proximate brands but having evidence to suggest that one is more familiar to the population allows assessment of the scale's ability to differentiate the organizations in the anticipated direction. Moreover, replicating the scale on a second organization helps to assess the scale's external validity and reliability.

Separate single-item measures for familiarity, attitude, and remarkability were included as alternate proxy measures to help assess convergent validity by comparing their means to those of the multi-item brand strength dimensional scales (Brackett and Mayer 2003). To help evaluate predictive and nomological validity, we measured six outcome variables, including conative outcomes (e.g., the intention to donate) and affective outcomes (e.g., trust) for both WV and OS (Table 3). To test these associations, we estimated multiple linear regression models for each outcome operationalized as single items following Walsh and Beatty's (2007) procedure.

Sample

An email list of 10,000 individuals was rented from First Direct Solutions (division of Australia Post). This list was chosen because it is updated annually through a national lifestyle survey, and it contains a 20 % proportion of the Australian population. There were 643 completed questionnaires (response rate = 6.4 %). With respect to gender, 34.5 % were male and 64.5 % were female. Ages of participants ranged from 18 to 87 years, with an average age of approximately 56 years.

Larger samples increase confidence that factor loadings reflect true population values. Research shows that a sample size of 150 observations should be sufficient to obtain an accurate solution in exploratory factor analysis as long as inter-correlations are reasonably strong (Guadagnoli and Velicer 1988). The item-to-participant ratio is 26.8 to 1, exceeding the 5 to 1 recommendation of Gorsuch (2003). The communalities are all greater than |.40|, exceeding Worthington and Whittaker's (2006) recommendation.

Factorability of the Correlation Matrix

We confirmed the factorability of the correlation matrix with a Kaiser–Meyer–Olkin (KMO) measure of sample adequacy of .963 for the WV data and of .968 for the OS data, exceeding the .60 cutoff recommended by Tabachnick and Fidell (2001). The anti-image of the correlation matrix was produced to generate a KMO measure for individual scale items, which were all well above the .60 threshold, ranging from .916 to .984. The Bartlett's Test of Sphericity was significant (correlation–covariance matrices and sufficient statistics needed to construct summary data matrices for these samples are available in Reviewer Appendices C and D).

Extraction and Rotation Methods

We followed scale development best practice recommendations and used factor analysis rather than principal components analysis (Worthington and Whittaker 2006). Principal axis factoring is a robust extraction method (Kamakura and Wedel 2000). Moderate correlations among factors can cause an overestimation of loadings if orthogonal rotation is used rather than oblique rotation (Loehlin 1998). Therefore, we used oblique rotation, following best practice recommendations (DeVellis 2011).

Factor analyses for both datasets produced three-factor solutions (Reviewer Appendix B). The factor eigenvalues from the WV data are 13.5, 4.2, and 1.7, and from the OS data, they are 16.7, 4.4, and 1.5. Scree tests show three factors above the elbow, confirming a three-factor solution.

According to Worthington and Whittaker (2006, p. 823), “researchers should delete items with factor loadings less than .32 or cross-loadings less than .15 difference from an item’s highest factor loading.” All of the WV items exceeded this factor loading threshold. However, three items did not exceed the .15 cross-loading cutoff. Furthermore, one additional item only exceeded the cross-loading cutoff by a trivial amount (cross-loading differential = .153). For OS data, all items exceeded the factor loading threshold and the difference thresholds from the highest loading. However, one item exceeded the cross-loading cutoff by a trivial amount (cross-loading = .158). We evaluated communalities, finding that all items, in both datasets, exceeded the recommended threshold of |.40| (Worthington and Whittaker 2006). Bagozzi and Yi (2012) recommend reporting composite reliabilities for multidimensional scales. They were .97 for each dataset.

Item Error Inter-correlations

In factor analysis, error terms are not allowed to correlate. Therefore, confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) using structural equation modeling (SEM) is useful in identifying items with high levels of shared error covariance which can negatively affect the psychometric properties of the scale (Netemeyer et al. 2003). Measurement models for each dataset were estimated, and problematic error covariance was

Table 1 Study 1: revised item pool after 1st study

No.	Item
Familiarity	
1	I am informed about [organization’s name]
2	I am knowledgeable about [organization’s name]’s activities
3	I am able to describe [organization’s name] to others
4	I have a good understanding of what [organization’s name] has done in the past
5	I have a good understanding of what [organization’s name] is currently doing
6	I understand the purpose of [organization’s name]
Remarkability	
7	[Organization’s name] is extraordinary compared with other nonprofit organizations
8	No organization is better than [organization’s name] at doing what it does
9	[Organization’s name] really stands apart as being exceptional
10	[Organization’s name] stands out in comparison to others
11	[Organization’s name] is memorable
12	[Organization’s name] is distinguished from other organizations
Attitude	
13	I have a favorable opinion of [organization’s name]
14	I believe that [organization’s name] is a great organization
15	I feel good about the work [organization’s name] is doing
16	I have positive thoughts when I think of [organization’s name]
17	I like [organization’s name]
18	I have a positive impression about [organization’s name]

identified using modification indexes (MIs). Only measurement errors producing high MIs for both datasets were used to identify problematic items. As a result of the EFA results and the CFA, six items were deleted (Table 1 presents the resulting 18 items).

Validity Evaluation Process

Convergent and discriminant validities were assessed using a combination method. A statistical approach recommended by Fornell and Larcker (1981) was applied. To further assess convergent validity, dimension means from the scale were compared to the means of single-item proxy measures of the dimensions included for this purpose. Prior research has found that single-item measures have predictive validity and, therefore, are appropriately used for our purposes (Bergkvist and Rossiter 2007). We expected the scale to differentiate the two organizations (discriminant validity). We expected WV's brand strength to be greater than OS's brand strength (predictive validity). To assess predictive validity further, we expected the outcome variable means to be greater for WV than for OS. In totality, these validity assessments along with high face validity (Rossiter 2011) help support construct validity of the scale.

Discriminant Validity

The ability of the scale to differentiate the brand strength of two peer brands was tested. The mean brand strength score (as well as for each dimension) for WV was significantly greater than it was for OS. Correlation coefficients were generated for WV and OS on each of the three dimensions to assess the strength of the association between these variables. For each of the three dimensions, the coefficient was less than .3, indicating a weak association (Mimmack et al. 2001, Reviewer Appendices C–E).

We also evaluated discriminant validity using the Fornell and Larcker (1981) procedure. Discriminant validity between two factors is shown if the individual average variance extracted (AVE) of one factor exceeds the squared correlation between the two factors. The squared correlations range from .12 to .58, and the AVE ranges from .68 to .97. For all factor pairs, the AVE exceeds the squared correlation, which provides evidence for discriminant validity (Table 2).

Convergent Validity

Convergent validity was assessed by calculating the average variance extracted (AVE) for each dimension. The AVE measures the amount of variance captured by a construct and has recommended values of .5 or higher to provide evidence for convergent validity (Fornell and Larcker 1981). All dimensions (Table 2) show AVEs higher than the cutoff. Convergent validity implies that alternative measures for a construct should be correlated. Thus, the correlations between the brand strength dimensions and the alternative single-item proxy measures were examined. The correlation coefficients range from .670 to .899, indicating strong associations

Table 2 Study 1: average variance extracted and shared variance estimates

	FAM WV	REM WV	AT WV
FAM WV	.82	.12	.18
REM WV	.34	.68	.50
AT WV	.42	.71	.88
	FAM OS	REM OS	AT OS
FAM OS	.94	.13	.21
REM OS	.36	.91	.58
AT OS	.45	.76	.97

Correlations are below the diagonal, squared correlations are above the diagonal, and average variance extracted estimates are presented on the diagonal

AT attitude, *FAM* familiarity, *OS* Operation Smile, *REM* remarkability, *WV* World Vision

between the measures and evidence of convergent validity (Wanous et al. 1997, Reviewer Appendix F).

Predictive and Nomological Validity

It is reasonable to expect that the nonprofit brand strength construct is antecedent to consequent variables in its nomological net. The scale's ability to demonstrate this relationship supports its predictive validity. As discussed previously, the brand strength means were significantly greater for WV than for OS. Likewise, the means of our outcome variables for WV are significantly greater than those for OS (Reviewer Appendices G and H).

Following Walsh and Beatty (2007), we calculated composite brand strength scores (average across all items) for both organizations. In a series of OLS regressions, one for each of the six outcome variables in which brand strength was the predictor variable and the outcome variable was the criterion, brand strength was a positive, substantive (beta values range from .55 to .62), significant predictor ($p < .001$) in each case (Table 3). These results support the predictive and nomological validity of the scale.

In the first developmental study, the scale demonstrated a three-factor structure, consistent with our a priori brand strength conceptualization. Six items were deleted, based on our EFA and CFA. A second developmental study was conducted to assess the refined scale.

Second Developmental Study

For this study, we chose Guide Dogs of Australia (GD) and World Wildlife Fund (WWF) as our brand objects. Readers Digest (2007) published survey results of the Australian population on which charities they most trusted. Guide Dogs of Australia was rated as the third most trusted charity. WWF was rated as the 45th most trusted

Table 3 Study 1: regression analyses of brand strength on outcome variables

Outcome	Org	Beta	t	R^2	Adj R^2
I would be more likely to make a donation to […] than to another organization	WV	.615	18.3*	.379	.377
	OS	.556	15.7*	.309	.308
I would be more likely to volunteer for […] than for another organization	WV	.549	15.4*	.302	.301
	OS	.551	15.5*	.303	.302
I would be more likely to tell others about […] rather than other organizations	WV	.595	17.4*	.354	.353
	OS	.580	16.7*	.337	.336
I trust […] more than other organizations	WV	.591	17.2*	.350	.349
	OS	.559	15.8*	.313	.312
I am more likely to visit […]'s website than those of other organizations	WV	.563	16.0*	.317	.315
	OS	.551	15.5*	.304	.302
I am more likely to recommend to others to support […] than other organizations	WV	.584	16.9*	.341	.340
	OS	.571	16.3*	.326	.325

* $p < .001$, t scores rounded to one decimal place, Brand Strength = Composite score, *Adj* adjusted, *Org* organization, *OS* Operation Smile, *WV* World Vision

charity. Given this ranking differential, it is reasonable to expect Guide Dog's brand strength to be greater than WWF's brand strength.

The questionnaire contained the 18 refined scale items from the first developmental study (Table 1). The questionnaire also included the same additional variable measures from the first study.

A second email list of 10,000 Australians (no duplications from the first email list) from First Direct Solution resulted in 639 completed questionnaires ($N = 639$; response rate = 6.4 %). The item-to-participant ratio in our sample is 35.5 to 1, and the communalities are all greater than |.40|. Among the sample respondents who indicated their gender ($n = 591$), 167 were male (28.3 %) and 424 were female (71.7 %). Ages of participants ranged from 18 to 87 years, with an average age of approximately 50 years (for correlation–covariance matrix and sufficient statistics to construct a summary data matrix see Reviewer Appendices I and J).

Exploratory Factor Analysis

We followed the same factor analytic procedures as in the first study. We verified the factorability of the correlation matrix with a KMO of .955 for the GD data and .957 for the WWF data and a significant Bartlett's Test of Sphericity (GD: $\chi^2 = 12{,}853$, d.f. = 153, $p < .001$; WWF: $\chi^2 = 15{,}730$, $p < .001$).

Our EFA produced a three-factor solution; with eigenvalues based on GD data of 10.6, 2.4, and 1.8; accounting for approximately 84 % of the variance; and with eigenvalues based on the WWF data of 11.7, 2.2, and 1.6; accounting for approximately 87 % of the variance. Both scree tests showed three factors above the elbow, supporting the three-factor solution. All items exceeded a factor loading of

.32 and the .15 cross-loading differential cutoffs. All item communalities exceeded the recommended threshold of .4. The composite reliabilities for the brand strength scale were .97 (WWF data) and .97 (GD data) (factor loadings are presented in Reviewer Appendix K).

Item Error Inter-correlations

We again conducted a CFA, with the exception of lowering the threshold for identifying a problematic item. Because the relationship between the dimensions and their items is reflective, as previously discussed, (1) the items are assumed to correlate, and (2) deleting an item does not materially alter the content validity of the scale (Coltman et al. 2008). Following the method used by Diamantopoulos and Siguaw (2006), the MIs for error inter-correlations were examined to identify items contributing to bias. If retention of a problematic item could not be defended on theoretical grounds (Danes and Mann 1984) and if its removal did not threaten the scale's ability to cover the conceptual domain (Bagozzi 1983), then it was deleted.

This process was repeated until reaching an RMSEA cutoff of .05 and a TLI cutoff of .95 (MacCallum et al. 1996; Reviewer Appendix L). The use of the two datasets improves the measurement model's reliability (Anderson and Gerbing 1982). This process resulted in the deletion of nine items, resulting in a nine item (3 items per dimension) scale. The final item set is presented in Table 4.

Discriminant Validity

Following the process described in the first study, we (1) tested the scale's ability to differentiate the two brands and (2) examined the AVE using Fornell and Larker's (1981) method. The mean brand strength score (as well as for each dimension) for GD was significantly greater than for WWF (Reviewer Appendix M). The AVE method resulted in squared correlations ranging from .27 to .39, and AVE ranging from .79 to .94. For all possible pairs of factors, the AVE exceeds the squared correlation, which provides evidence for discriminant validity (Reviewer Appendix N).

Convergent Validity

As in the first study, convergent validity was assessed by examining the AVE for each dimension, all of which exceeded the .50 cutoff (Reviewer Appendix N). Additionally, the correlations between the brand strength dimensions and the alternative single-item proxy measures were examined. The correlation coefficients ranged from .582 to .872, indicating moderate to strong associations between the measures and evidence of convergent validity (Reviewer Appendix O).

Predictive and Nomological Validity

Following the procedure described in the prior study, we conducted a series of regressions to determine if brand strength was related to outcome variables one would expect. The results of the regression analysis resulted in significant

Table 4 Study 2: refined item pool after 2nd study

No.	Item
Familiarity	
1	I am knowledgeable about [organization's name]'s activities
2	I am able to describe [organization's name] to others
3	I have a good understanding of what [organization's name] has done in the past
Remarkability	
4	No organization is better than [organization's name] at doing what it does
5	[Organization's name] really stands apart as being exceptional
6	[Organization's name] stands out in comparison to others
Attitude	
7	I have positive thoughts when I think of [organization's name]
8	I like [organization's name]
9	I have a positive impression about [organization's name]

relationships (at $p < .001$) between the predictor variable (brand strength) and each outcome variable (beta coefficients ranged from .24 to .51; R^2's ranged from .06 to .26) (Reviewer Appendix P).

Because Guide Dogs is a more popular charity than WWF, one would expect that DG's brand strength to be greater than WWF's—which it was as discussed previously. One would also expect the mean scores for the outcome variables to be greater for GD than for WWF. Indeed, the means for the GD's outcome measures proved to be significantly greater than those for WWF, providing additional support for the predictive validity and nomological validity of the brand strength scale (Reviewer Appendix Q).

Study 3: Cross-Validation Study

A third study, using a new sample, was conducted to cross-validate the scale. As in the prior studies, we used two nonprofit organizations as our brand objects: the American Red Cross (RC) and Doctors Without Borders (DWB). Thus, both organizations are relatively well known, yet the RC appears to be slightly more popular (in the rankings of Charity Navigator (2012), RC is 1st, DWB is 3rd). These organizations were selected to assess the scale's ability to differentiate two organizations that are quite close with respect to popularity out of a large pool. Hence, the close proximity of these two brand objects serves as a rigorous test of the scale's ability to distinguish peer brands.

Sample

A sample from a different country was used to assess the scale's external validity. A U.S. sample was obtained using SurveyMonkey, resulting in 523 completed questionnaires ($N = 523$). Our sample's average age was approximately 48 years, and there were 246 (46.9 %) male and 276 (52.7 %) female respondents.

Confirmatory Factor Analysis

Separate CFA was performed on the RC data and the DWB data. We compared the fit of the measurement model on the two datasets; finding significant and sizable loadings for items on their respective dimensions (Fig. 2 for loadings and Reviewer Appendices R and S for data summary tables).

When calculating the estimates for the measurement model using the RC data, the error variance for the remarkability dimension was negative.

The χ^2-statistic (CMIN statistic in AMOS) for the model using the RC data was 67.7 (d.f. $= 25$, $p = .000$) and was 62.9 (d.f. $= 24$, $p = .000$) using the DWB data. This overall fit statistic is highly sensitive to sample size (Kline 2010). Samples with more than 200 cases having small differences between the observed and the reproduced covariance matrices can result in a significant χ^2 (Schumaker and Lomax 2004). Because of this and other issues related to SEM fit indices, researchers have expressed various preferences and recommendations (Byrne 2001). Therefore, we will include an array of fit indices for both datasets in Reviewer Appendix T.

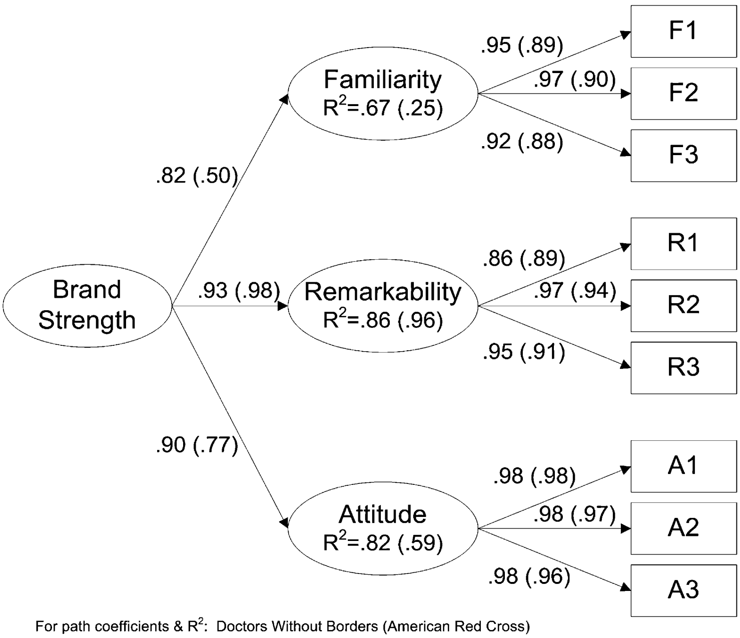

Fig. 2 Study 3: confirmatory factor analysis: the three-factor model

We primarily rely on the incremental fit indices TLI and CFI to evaluate the overall goodness-of-fit of our measurement model. We rely primarily on the RMSEA coefficient as a badness-of-fit indicator (the lower the score, the better the fit). In a content analysis of CFA articles published in Psychological Methods between 1998 and 2006, the reported mean RMSEA was .064 (reported in 357 articles), the mean TLI was .904 (reported in 315 articles), and the mean CFI was .929 (reported in 322 articles) (Jackson et al. 2009). The brand strength measurement model using the RC data produced an RMSEA of .058, a TLI of .988, and a CFI of .992. For the DWB data, our model resulted in an RMSEA of .056, a TLI of .992, and a CFI of .995. These results indicate a good fit for both datasets and were superior to indices reported by Jackson et al. (2009), exceeding recommended thresholds (Bagozzi and Yi 1988).

Reliability

The composite reliabilities for the brand strength scale were .98 (DWB data) and .97 (RC data).

Discriminant Validity

We tested the ability of the scale to distinguish between the two brands. We expected RC to have a higher level of brand strength than DWB because of its slightly greater popularity (1st and 3rd, respectively, out of 1100 charities). We followed the procedures used in the prior two studies (Reviewer Appendix U). The brand strength dimension and composite means are all significantly greater for RC than for DWB. Further assessment, using the Fornell and Larcker (1981) process, found that all AVE estimates are greater than all squared correlations, also supporting the scale's discriminant validity (Reviewer Appendix V).

Convergent Validity

As in the prior two studies, we used single-item dimension proxy measures to aid in examining convergent validity. Correlation coefficients range from .613 to .888, indicating a strong and positive relationship and, therefore, providing support for convergent validity (Reviewer Appendix W). Moreover, convergent validity was achieved with all AVE estimates for both datasets (Reviewer Appendix V), exceeding the .5 threshold, ranging from .79 to .96.

External Validity

The external validity of the scale is also supported. This is the third study in which the scale has been shown to differentiate a pair of brand objects with the expected relationship. Hence, the scale has been used to measure our construct for six organizations (our brand objects), using three samples, from two countries.

Nomological Validity

Following prior research for establishing nomological validity (Podsakoff and MacKenzie 1994; Walsh and Beatty 2007), we examine how well the brand strength scale relates to other variables. The questionnaire included three antecedent and two consequent variables for RC brand strength, whose appropriateness of operationalization was tested by a CFA each (items based on prior research and results CFAs, Table 5). There were three brand strength antecedents: (1) an individual's value

Table 5 Study 3: antecedent and consequent variables of brand strength

	Coefficients of determination (from CFA) and composite reliabilities
Antecedents	
Individual's value concordance/harmony with organization[a]	AVE = .75, cr = .90
I care about what the Red Cross represents	.87
I share the Red Cross's concern for people	.87
I feel that the Red Cross represents some values that are important to me	.86
Exposure to organizational communication[b]	AVE = .46, cr = .63
The Red Cross has sent me mail or email	.66
The Red Cross appears to advertise on a regular basis	.70
Personal experience[c]	AVE = .62, cr = .83
I have had personal experience with the Red Cross	.67
I know people who have supported or been helped by the Red Cross	.84
I have witnessed how the Red Cross can make a positive difference	.83
Consequences	
Intention for behavioral support[d]	AVE = .65, cr = .85
I am likely to donate to the Red Cross in the future	.81
I am likely to volunteer for the Red Cross in the future	.71
I am likely to recommend to others to support the Red Cross	.90
Affective response to organization[e]	AVE = .52, cr = .75
I could be a loyal supporter of the Red Cross	.88
I trust the Red Cross	.77
I would not like hearing or reading something critical about the Red Cross	.46

AVE average variance extracted, *cr* composite reliability

[a] Developed after Aaker et al. (2004), Bendapudi et al. (1996), and Mael and Ashforth (1992)

[b] Developed after Bendapudi et al. (1996) and Yoo et al. (2000)

[c] Developed after Bendapudi et al. (1996) and Delgado-Ballester (2004)

[d] Developed after Samu and Wymer (2009) and Venable et al. (2005)

[e] Developed after Walsh and Beatty (2007)

concordance with the charity's mission, (2) exposure to communications from the charity, and (3) personal experiences with the charity. There were two brand strength consequent variables: (1) intention for behavioral support, and (2) affective response to the organization. The appropriateness of the variable operationalizations was supported with composite reliability coefficients (ranging from .63 to .90, Table 5). These measures are expected to be positively associated with brand strength.

Given the predicted positive association between the antecedent variables and brand strength, and between brand strength and the consequent variables, correlations were examined to assess nomological validity (Walsh and Beatty 2007). All correlations were significant at $p < .01$, supporting nomological validity (Reviewer Appendix X).

Discussion

Marketing managers desire a strong brand in order to achieve its expected benefits. We conceptualized nonprofit brand strength as a three-dimensional construct (familiarity, attitude, and remarkability). The three-dimensional conceptualization was supported in the initial EFA's factor structure, prior to any item changes. It was supported again in the EFA of the second study, and then confirmed in the third study's CFA. The final nonprofit brand strength scale is parsimonious, consisting of nine items. Psychometrically, the scale is internally consistent and reliable across samples and brand objects. The items have a high level of face validity resulting from the rigorous initial item pool generation and refinement process employed.

The scale, in three separate studies, was able to discriminate between peer brands in the expected direction. Furthermore, this discrimination was also replicated at the dimension level in each case, supporting both the discriminant validity of the scale and the conceptualization of the construct. The Fornell and Larcker (1981) average variance extracted (AVE) procedure also supported the discriminant and convergent validity of the scale in each study.

The scale's convergent validity was supported not only by the AVE procedure, but also by comparing the scale's measurements with those of single-item proxy measures having high face validity. In each study, this comparison resulted in significant correlations with strong associations at both the dimension level and at the composite level.

The scale's nomological validity was supported by examining the associations between the scale and variables with which nonprofit brand strength should be related. In the cross-validation study, variables which one would expect to be antecedents of nonprofit brand strength and consequents of nonprofit brand strength were examined. In all cases, the correlations were significant, and the strength of the associations was strong. Hence, the findings support the conceptualization of the nonprofit brand strength construct and the construct validity of the nonprofit brand strength scale.

Research Implications

Our research advances prior research on nonprofit brand strength by providing a thorough conceptualization of the construct and by developing a scale for its measurement. Our literature review revealed that prior research in the brand area was often conducted with an intentional or inadvertent bias in that researchers often assumed the brand object was a consumer product, the target group was consumers, and the marketing organization was a corporation. Given the marketing discipline's origins and history, this contextual assumption is understandable, but can produce weak scientific results. We avoided this biasing effect by conceptualizing nonprofit brand strength in a manner that would be appropriate for an array of objects. In the scale development program, we chose to use nonprofit organizations as our brand objects. However, the scale items can be adapted for other brand objects.

One important measurement issue deals with the relative influence of each dimension on the brand strength composite score. It is reasonable to believe that the influence of each dimension on brand strength is unequal. That is, the influence of familiarity, remarkability, and attitude on brand strength may be different. In our study, we have treated the dimensions and construct as an aggregate model (Law et al. 1998).

Hence, if a manager uses the brand strength scale and calculates brand strength using a simple summing and averaging of dimensions, without respect to differential weighting, does this reduce the practical utility of the scale? We will now discuss this issue.

We have not weighted the dimensions based on theoretical considerations. We do not have a theoretical foundation to support the assignment of weights to the various dimensions. Thus, we are left with a data-driven approach to calculating dimensional weights (Decancq and Lugo 2013). Weights derived from one or a small number of samples are unlikely to be stable across a large number of samples (Grice and Harris 1998).

The appropriate data-driven way to develop appropriate dimension weights is to conduct a meta-analysis of prior studies that measured brand strength, then to calculate an average loading score for each dimension across an array of samples. Dimension loadings in large samples could be given greater weight than loadings in small samples (Lipsey and Wilson 2001). This would result in more reliable weights that are more stable across samples (Grice and Harris 1998). Since we are developing an original scale, it will be some time before data-driven weights derived from a meta-analysis are possible.

Our findings will enable research scholars to more fully investigate phenomena within the brand nomological net. It appears that nonprofit brand strength may serve an important role. It serves a mediation role between marketing activities and desired outcomes. Nonprofit brand strength may also be a leading indicator of change for desired marketing outcomes. It may be the case that nonprofit marketing managers would be more likely to achieve brand success by focusing their efforts at increasing brand strength. If nonprofit brand strength is antecedent to desired outcome variables, then its periodic measurement using our scale would provide a more time-sensitive and predictive means of evaluative feedback of marketing planning. Hence, ineffective tactics could be corrected and effective tactics more strongly emphasized in a timelier manner, which would provide a better use of marketing resources and improve the probability of success. These are all issues which could be the subject of future research.

Managerial Implications

The managerial implications of nonprofit brand strength are derived from the nomological net position of brand strength as a consequent of marketing activities and as an antecedent of marketing outcomes. Managerially, then, nonprofit brand strength is an important construct to understand, measure, and monitor. Nonprofit brand strength may be a fulcrum through which marketing tactics are leveraged to achieve desirable objectives. Hence, the ability to have a simple means of measuring brand strength provides nonprofit managers with the ability of more precisely assessing the effects of their marketing tactics. Also, brand strength may be found to be a leading indicator of marketing outcomes specific to the nonprofit organization and also in relation to peer brands.

We believe that the brand strength scale has practical importance for managers even if a more simplistic unweighted average of the dimensions is used for its calculation. We anticipate that the three main purposes for which managers would use the brand strength scale are

- To differentiate one organization's brand strength from another organization's brand strength,
- To use in periodic brand strength measurement for trend analysis, and
- To predict changes in outcome variables from changes in brand strength.

Nonprofit managers may also find brand strength to be diagnostically beneficial for feedback and control purposes. For example, if the brand strength score was low, one could assume that audience members cannot meaningfully evaluate the brand object. Hence, the manager should communicate more to target audiences to increase brand familiarity. If brand familiarity is high, but brand remarkability and brand attitude are low, the manager is probably safe in assuming that the audience believes the brand object has lower quality, lower value, or performs worse than it should. If brand familiarity is high, brand attitude is high, but brand remarkability is low, this could be indicative of a well-known charity that is perceived to be no better than average in fulfilling its mission (yet the charity evokes a favorable attitude because of the selfless nature of its work). If brand familiarity is high, brand remarkability is moderate, and brand attitude is low, this could be indicative of a well-known brand that is exceptionally bad (think of an oil company that had a catastrophic oil spill). In sum, the dimension scores provide information in addition to contributing to the brand strength score that may offer managers some insights (or direct their attention for the need of further information).

Nonprofit managers may find that emphasizing specific brand strength dimensions in their marketing activities will depend upon their competitive positioning. Managers may find that emphasizing the remarkability of their nonprofit brand may lack verisimilitude if their brand is not well known. Managers of the strongest nonprofit brands, however, might achieve the greatest return from their marketing communications by emphasizing the remarkability of their brands. Finally, and perhaps most important, our findings emphasize the need for nonprofit managers to look for innovative ways to make their brand objects truly excellent, exceptional, exemplary; that is, remarkable; and then find effective ways of communicating that remarkability to important audiences.

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